

RH11

Painting Schools and Handicrafts

About 2–3 questions a paper. Painting gives you one match-the-following almost every year; handicrafts gives one craft-to-district one-liner.

Two halves, one method. Painting is school-to-painter-to-patron matching; handicrafts is craft-to-centre matching. RESEARCH puts painting schools matched to painters in the 2013, 2018 and 2024 papers — it is one of the most reliable repeat clusters in the whole exam.

Painting & Handicrafts

Mewar

- Chawand Ragmala 1605
- Sahibdin
- Manohar
- Nathdwara Pichwai
- Deogarh

Marwar & Bikaner

- Shiv Das
- Dhola-Maru
- Ali Raza
- Ruknuddin

Metal & clay

- Thewa Pratapgarh
- Meenakari Jaipur
- Koftgiri Udaipur
- Usta Bikaner
- Blue pottery
- Molela

Hadoti

- Bundi – Chunar Ragmala 1591
- Kota – shikar scenes
- Uniara (Tonk)

Dhundhar & Alwar

- Sahib Ram
- Bihari Satsai
- Baldev
- ivory painting

Wood & folk

- Kavad Bassi
- Phad Shahpura
- Kathputli puppets

Kishangarh

- Nihal Chand
- Bani Thani
- Savant Singh / Nagari Das
- Gundalao lake

Textile crafts

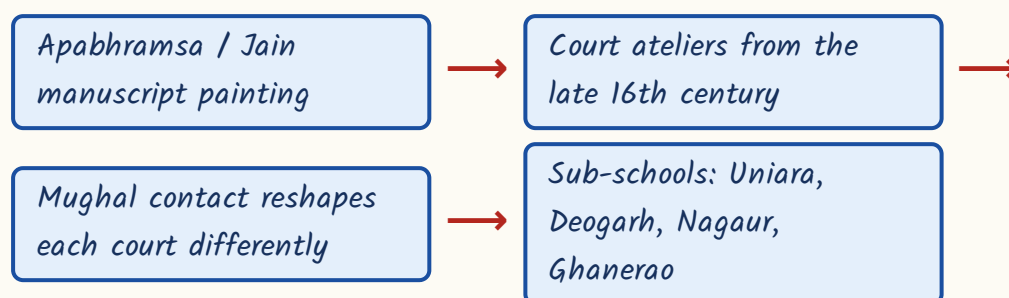
- Bandhej
- Leheriya
- Bagru dabu
- Sanganeri
- Ajrakh Barmer
- Kota Doria

Where Rajasthani painting comes from, and how to attack the chapter

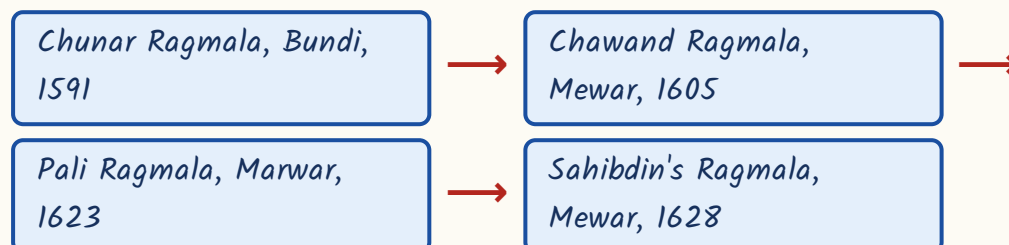
Rajasthani painting grew out of the Western Indian Apabhramsa and Jain manuscript tradition — the illustrated palm-leaf and paper manuscripts of the Jain merchants. From the late sixteenth century these miniatures develop into court schools, collectively called the Rajasthani or Rajput school. Mughal contact modifies each school differently; that is why Bikaner looks Mughal-Deccani and Mewar stays flat and bright.

Now the method. RPSC does not ask you to describe a style. It asks you to pair a name with a school. So build three lists in your head: school-to-painter, school-to-patron, school-to-signature-work. Everything else is background. The dated Ragmala sets give you a ready-made chronology question as a bonus.

How the schools came to be



The dated Ragmala sets — the ordering question RPSC has already built



YAAD RAKHO

Yaad rakho the four dates as 91-05-23-28. Chunar 1591 is Bundi and is the EARLIEST of the lot — students routinely put Mewar's 1605 first because Mewar feels older as a kingdom. It is not.

Mewar — the school with the greatest master

Mewar is the oldest continuous school. Its earliest dated set is a Ragmala painted at Chawand in 1605 by Nisaruddin, under Maharana Amar Singh I — Chawand was then the Mewar capital. But the school's greatest name comes a generation later.

- Sahibdin is the greatest master of the Mewar school; he worked under Maharana Jagat Singh I.
- His works: Ragmala of 1628, Rasikpriya, Bhagavata Purana, and the Yuddha Kanda of the Ramayana.
- The other Mewar painter to remember is Manohar.
- Style marks: flat bright colour, oval faces, pointed noses.
- Sub-centres of the Mewar region: Nathdwara, Deogarh, Ghanerao.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 — Sahibdin, the greatest painter of the Mewar school, worked chiefly under which ruler? Answer: Maharana Jagat Singh I. Do not answer Amar Singh I; he is the Chawand Ragmala patron, 1605.

Hadoti — Bundi and Kota, one parent and one offshoot

Bundi and Kota are treated as one family because Kota grew out of Bundi. But their subject matter is completely different, and that difference is exactly what gets asked. Bundi paints nature and the monsoon. Kota paints the hunt.

Bundi vs Kota

Bundi school	Kota school
Earliest work: <i>Chunar Ragmala</i> , 1591, for Rao Bhoj Singh	An offshoot of Bundi, later
Lush vegetation, monsoon skies, elephants, red-brown ground	Shikar (hunting) scenes in dense dark forest, tiny human figures
Chitrashala of the Bundi palace is its great mural site	Flourished under Maharao Ram Singh and Umed Singh
-	Painter: Raghunath Das

- The *Chunar Ragmala* was painted by artists trained in the Mughal atelier — hence its early Mughal feel.
- *Uniara (Tonk)* is a sub-school that blends Bundi and Jaipur styles.
- Kota's treatment — small figures set against a dark forest mass — is found in no other Rajasthani school.

Kishangarh — the smallest school, the most famous painting

Kishangarh is a small state that produced the single most recognisable Rajasthani painting. Raja Savant Singh, who ruled 1748-57 and wrote Krishna-bhakti poetry under the pen-name Nagari Das, patronised the painter Nihal Chand. Bani Thani, a singer at his court, was the model. The portrait is called the Indian Mona Lisa.

- Painter: Nihal Chand. Patron: Raja Savant Singh, pen-name Nagari Das.
- Other Kishangarh painters: Amar Chand, Sitaram, Soorajmal.

- *Style: elongated upturned eyes, arched eyebrows, pointed chin and nose.*
- *Themes: Krishna-Radha, Morchhal, boat scenes.*
- *Background: the panoramic Gundalao lake of Kishangarh.*

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 — the painting Bani Thani of the Kishangarh school was executed by whom? Answer: Nihal Chand. A companion question asks the pen-name of his patron: Nagari Das.

Marwar, Bikaner, Dhundhar, Alwar — and the master table

These four are almost always taught as a block because RPSC puts them together in one List-I. Learn the table below cold. It is the single highest-return thing in this chapter.

School to painter to patron to signature work

School	Painter(s)	Patron & signature work
Mewar	Sahibdin, Manohar	Maharana Jagat Singh I; Ragmala 1628, Rasikpriya
Bundi	Mughal-trained artists	Rao Bhoj Singh; Chunar Ragmala 1591
Kota	Raghunath Das	Maharao Ram Singh, Umed Singh; shikar scenes
Kishangarh	Nihal Chand	Raja Savant Singh (Nagari Das); Bani Thani
Marwar / Jodhpur	Shiv Das, Kishan Das, Dana, Amardas, Kalu, Virji	Maharaja Man Singh (Nath subjects); Dhola-Maru, Pali Ragmala 1623
Bikaner	Ali Raza (Ustad), Ruknuddin, Shahadin, Nathu	Rai Singh, Karan Singh, Anup Singh; signed and dated works
Dhundhar (Amber-Jaipur)	Sahib Ram, Ghasi Ram, Hukma, Guman	Sawai Pratap Singh; life-size portraits, Bihari Satsai

School	Painter(s)	Patron & signature work
Alwar	Baldev, Ghasi Ram, Sali Ram, Jamna Das	Maharao Raja Vinay Singh; ivory painting, Gulistan miniatures

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2013 — Ali Raza and Ruknuddin are the celebrated painters of which school? Answer: Bikaner. The reason for its Mughal-Deccani look is worth knowing: Karan Singh and Anup Singh served long spells in the Deccan. Bikaner artists were also unusual in signing and dating their work.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 — the painter Shiv Das belongs to which school? Answer: Marwar (Jodhpur). The Marwar signature theme is the Dhola-Maru romance. In RAS Pre 2018 the same idea came as a painter-to-school match set.

TRAP

Sahib Ram is JAIPUR (Dhundhar), not Bundi. RPSC has used Bundi-Sahib Ram as the wrong pair in a NOT-correctly-matched question. Also note Ghasi Ram appears in both the Jaipur and Alwar lists — if the option pairs Ghasi Ram with ivory painting, it is Alwar.

Folk and devotional painting — Pichwai, Phad, Kavadi

Alongside the court schools runs a devotional and narrative tradition. These three are asked as place questions, not style questions.

- Pichwai — large cloth paintings hung behind the Shrinathji image at Nathdwara, Rajsamand district; they change with the season and the festival.
- Phad — long cloth scrolls narrating Pabuji and Devnarayan; painted at Shahpura in Bhilwara district by the Joshi (Chhipa) family.
- Devnarayan ki Phad is the longest; Pabuji ki Phad is the most widely performed.
- The Bhopa narrates the Pabuji phad to the Ravanhatha, and the Devnarayan phad to the Jantar.
- Kavadi — a portable painted wooden shrine with hinged panels, made by Suthar craftsmen at Bassi, Chittorgarh; a Kavadiya Bhat opens it panel by panel while telling the story. Bassi is also known for wooden toys and puppets.
- Basohli is NOT a Rajasthani school — it belongs to the Pahari group in Jammu. Uniara, Nagaur, Deogarh, Ghanerao, Shahpura and Sirohi are the genuine Rajasthani sub-centres.

YAAD RAKHO

Three folk forms, three districts, one line: Pichwai at Nathdwara in RAJSAMAND, Phad at Shahpura in BHILWARA, Kavadi at Bassi in CHITTORGARH. P-P-K, R-B-C. Options in this chapter shuffle exactly these three districts.

Handicrafts I — textiles, the craft-to-centre table

Handicrafts is asked one way only: which place. So build the table place-first. Learn the district for each craft, and learn the two crafts that are constantly swapped.

Textile craft to centre

Craft	Centre / district	What it is
<i>Bandhej (tie-and-dye)</i>	<i>Jaipur, Sikar, Jodhpur, Udaipur, Nathdwara</i>	<i>Cloth tied in points and dyed</i>
<i>Leheriya</i>	<i>Jaipur, Jodhpur, Udaipur</i>	<i>Diagonal stripes made by resist-tying</i>
<i>Sanganeri printing</i>	<i>Sanganer, Jaipur</i>	<i>Fine floral DIRECT block printing on a white ground</i>
<i>Bagru printing</i>	<i>Bagru, Jaipur district</i>	<i>Dabu (mud-resist) printing in earthy red and black; syahi-begar prints</i>
<i>Ajrakh printing</i>	<i>Barmer and Balotra</i>	<i>Geometric prints in indigo and madder, by the Khatri community</i>
<i>Kota Doria</i>	<i>Kaithoon, near Kota</i>	<i>Khat weave of cotton and silk giving square checks; GI-registered</i>
<i>Namda</i>	<i>Tonk</i>	<i>Felted woollen rugs</i>
<i>Pattu</i>	<i>Jaisalmer and Barmer</i>	<i>Woollen shawl</i>
<i>Jajam</i>	<i>Akola (Chittorgarh), Bhilwara</i>	<i>Block-printed floor spread</i>
<i>Gotta-kinari</i>	<i>Khandela (Sikar), Ajmer, Jaipur</i>	<i>Metallic ribbon applied on fabric</i>
<i>Danka work</i>	<i>Udaipur</i>	<i>The Udaipur counterpart of gotta work</i>
<i>Zari / Zardozi</i>	<i>Jaipur, Bikaner</i>	<i>Metal-thread embroidery</i>

Bagru vs Sanganeri — the single most swapped pair in handicrafts

Bagru	Sanganeri
<i>Dabu, i.e. mud-RESIST printing</i>	<i>Direct block printing</i>
<i>Earthy reds and blacks; syahi-begar</i>	<i>Fine floral motifs, delicate lines</i>
<i>Usually on an off-white or dyed ground</i>	<i>On a white ground</i>
<i>Bagru village, Jaipur district</i>	<i>Sanganer town, Jaipur</i>

TRAP

Kota Doria is woven at Kaithoon in KOTA district — not Bhilwara.

Bhilwara's association is phad painting at Shahpura and textile mills. RPSC has used Kota Doria-Bhilwara as the wrong pair.

Handicrafts II — metal, clay, glass and wood

Same drill. One line per craft: the place and the technique. Techniques matter here because RPSC has asked a craft-to-technique match set.

Craft to centre to technique

Craft	Centre	Technique
Thewa	Pratapgarh	Engraved sheet gold fused on to coloured glass; the hereditary Raj Soni family
Meenakari	Jaipur	Enamelling; brought in when Raja Man Singh I fetched enamellers from Lahore
Koftgiri	Udaipur, Alwar, Jaipur	Gold or silver wire inlaid into steel
Usta art (munawwat)	Bikaner	Gold embossing and painting on camel hide; seen in Junagarh's Anup Mahal
Blue pottery	Jaipur	Quartz powder, fuller's earth, borax, gum and glass — NO clay
Molela terracotta	Molela, Rajsamand	Votive clay plaques, chiefly of Devnarayan, by Kumhar craftsmen
Kavad	Bassi, Chittorgarh	Painted wooden shrine with hinged panels, by Suthar craftsmen
Marble carving	Jaipur; marble from Makrana, Nagaur	Makrana supplied the white marble of the Taj Mahal

Pottery — four types, four places

Type	Place
Blue pottery	Jaipur
Black pottery	Sawai Madhopur, Kota
Kagzi (paper-thin) pottery	Alwar
Terracotta plaques	Molela, Rajsamand

TRAP

Blue pottery contains no clay at all. Its dough is quartz powder, fuller's earth, borax, gum and glass — and the low firing temperature is why the ware is fragile. Any statement calling clay its main ingredient is the wrong one. It reached Jaipur from Persia through Kashmir and Delhi, was encouraged by Sawai Ram Singh II, and was revived in the twentieth century by Kripal Singh Shekhawat.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2013 — Molela, famous for votive terracotta plaques of folk deities, is in which district? Answer: Rajsamand. Molela lies near Nathdwara, and its plaques of Devnarayan are installed by Bhil and Gurjar devotees in village shrines.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): a cluster of Rajasthan crafts received Geographical Indication tags in August 2023 — Nathdwara Pichwai, Jodhpuri Bandhej, Udaipur Koftgiri, Bikaner Usta art and Bikaner embroidery. Nagauri Ashwagandha received a GI tag in January 2026 and was widely reported as the state's twenty-second GI product. Published totals vary between 22 and 23 depending on how food and craft items are counted, so learn the PRODUCTS and their years, not the running total. Older Rajasthan GI crafts include Blue Pottery, Bagru print, Sanganeri print, Kota Doria, Molela pottery, Thewa and Makrana marble. Rajasthali is the state handicraft emporium.

REVISION RECAP

1. Rajasthani painting descends from the Western Indian Apabhramsa / Jain manuscript tradition.
2. Ragmala order: Chunar (Bundi) 1591, Chawand (Mewar) 1605, Pali (Marwar) 1623, Sahibdin's 1628.
3. Mewar: Sahibdin under Jagat Singh I; Chawand 1605 set painted by Nisaruddin under Amar Singh I.
4. Bundi = monsoon, vegetation, elephants, Chitrashala. Kota = shikar scenes, Ram Singh and Umed Singh, painter Raghunath Das.
5. Kishangarh: Nihal Chand, patron Savant Singh alias Nagari Das, Bani Thani = Indian Mona Lisa, Gundalao lake backgrounds.
6. Marwar: Shiv Das, Kishan Das, Dana; theme Dhola-Maru; Nath subjects under Maharaja Man Singh.
7. Bikaner: Ali Raza and Ruknuddin; Mughal-Deccani influence; artists signed and dated their work.
8. Jaipur/Dhundhar: Sahib Ram, life-size portraits, Bihari Satsai, patron Sawai Pratap Singh. Alwar: Baldev and Ghasi Ram, ivory painting, Vinay Singh.
9. Pichwai = Nathdwara (Rajsamand). Phad = Shahpura (Bhilwara), Joshi family. Kavadi = Bassi (Chittorgarh).
10. Devnarayan phad is the longest and is narrated to the Jantar; Pabuji phad is narrated to the Ravanhatha.
11. Blue pottery: Jaipur, no clay, revived by Kripal Singh Shekhawat.
12. Thewa = Pratapgarh, Raj Soni family, gold on glass. Usta = Bikaner, gold on camel hide.
13. Koftgiri = wire inlay on steel (Udaipur); Meenakari = enamelling (Jaipur, via Man Singh I from Lahore).
14. Bagru = dabu mud-resist; Sanganer = fine floral direct printing. Ajrakh = Barmer/Balotra, Khatri community.
15. Kota Doria at Kaithoon, Kota district; Namda at Tonk; Pattu at Jaisalmer-Barmer; Gotta-kinari at Khandela, Sikar.
16. Pottery: blue Jaipur, black Sawai Madhopur-Kota, kagzi Alwar, terracotta Molela. Makrana marble from Nagaur.